fighter aircraft. They entered deep into Pakistani territory, dropping bombs in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, which was in the vicinity of the town of Balakot.

The airstrike was immediately confirmed by the Pakistani military, but with the proviso that the Indian planes had only managed to drop their payload in an uninhabited wooded hilltop area. India nevertheless declared that it as a pre-emptive strike against a terrorist training camp and controversially maintained that of its bombs, 'four penetrated the rooftops of the building in which the terrorists were sleeping'.[2] In the days and weeks that followed, relations between the two countries plummeted to an all-time low in what had once been described by US President Bill Clinton as 'the most dangerous place on earth'.[3] Soon it was lamented that '[t]he "all or nothing" policy that the Narendra Modi government has followed towards Pakistan has failed. Bilateral relations have deteriorated and violence in Kashmir is at a new high'. [4] Within a month, the bad blood between the two countries had reached such a crescendo that the Indian government even boycotted the Pakistan National Day and stopped Indians from attending a programme at the Pakistan High Commission on 23 March 2019.[5]

On the same day in Pakistan, however, something quite different was stirring. Given that it was amid the febrile atmosphere of two nuclear powers now poised to go to war with each other, it was all the more unexpected. And, it was taking place in the very heart of Lahore, in what was once the citadel of cosmopolitanism, memorialized in a slogan which every Lahori has on his lips when he meets a non-Lahori. The origins of this slogan have all but now been forgotten—'*jeneh Lahore nahin dekhya oh jamiyan nahin*', which translates into, 'He who has not seen Lahore has not enjoyed being born.' That day was the 88th Martyrdom Day of Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev, who had been hastily executed by the colonial government for the murder of a British police officer, J.P. Saunders.[6] Amid the prospect of a looming cross-border war, Lahoris on this day refused to be cowed and were determined to celebrate the Lahore that once was—the Lahore of many cities, of many cultures, of many diverse faiths. They thronged its streets, unperturbed and with not a care in the world. Rising